Code review skills: built-in vs own

/code-review (built into Claude Code 2.1.302, default level "high") compared with **/reviewBranch** (own skill). Test: repository AlliumAssault, 2 branches, 2 runs per skill and branch, model Opus 5.5. 17 Oct 2026.

> **Recommendation: keep /reviewBranch as the default. Add /code-review before an important merge.**
> /reviewBranch gives a short list that you can trust. /code-review finds more problems, but you must sort half of its list yourself. Both skills found the one important bug every time. Neither skill reported a false finding.

88% · 47%	**5 · 11**	**$0.71 · $0.57**	**4 / 4 · 4 / 4**
Precision: real findings ÷ reported findings	Different real defects found (all runs together)	Median cost per review (tie: below the 25% rule)	Runs that found the one medium-severity bug

MEASURED RESULT

Branch	Skill	Cost USD	Tokens	Turns	Time s	Reported	Real	Weak / old
Media script (15 files)	reviewBranch	0.60–0.61	383–498 k	9–11	101–109	1–3	1–2	0–1
	code-review	0.50–0.51	334–340 k	9	109–112	10	5–6	4–5
Game feature (21 files)	reviewBranch	0.81–0.84	878 k–1.0 M	18–20	113–166	2	2	0
	code-review	0.64	691–768 k	14–17	123–141	9	3–4	5–6

"Real" = a confirmed defect in the new code. "Weak / old" = true, but trivial, only possible in theory, or present before the branch. We checked each of the 46 findings in the code.

WHERE THEY ARE THE SAME

- Both find the important bug: a team without a set faction moves to a different alliance when you remove a team.
- Both report no false findings. Both take about 2 minutes. Both cost less than one US dollar per review.

WHERE THEY ARE DIFFERENT

/reviewBranch — the decision

Better

- It checks each finding before it reports it.
- It puts the important bug at rank 1.
- It gives a severity and a merge verdict.
- It finds the correct base branch (master, main, develop).
- You own the text. It changes only when you change it.

Weaker

- It misses small defects in documents and conventions.
- It does not review uncommitted changes.
- It costs about 25% more per run.

/code-review — the search

Better

- It finds all defects that /reviewBranch finds, plus 6 more.
- It checks project rules, duplicate code and speed.
- It can fix code, comment on pull requests and run a cloud review ("ultra").
- It runs in a separate agent. Your session stays clean.

Weaker

- At the default level, it does not verify its findings.
- It tries to report at least 5 findings. Half are weak or old.
- It has no severity and no merge verdict.
- Its base-branch logic can miss commits on "master" repositories.
- Anthropic changes its text with each release.

WHAT TO DO

- **Every branch:** run **/reviewBranch**. Fix the findings it reports.
- **Before a release or a large merge:** also run **/code-review**. Expect extra findings, and sort them before you act.
- **Improve /reviewBranch:** add a check of project rules (AGENTS.md, CLAUDE.md) and of documents that the branch makes out of date.

Limits: one repository, two branches, two runs per cell. We tested only the default level of /code-review; the levels "max" and "ultra" add verification and can change the precision result. The precision gate is narrow: one more real finding moves /code-review to 50%. Method, decision rule (fixed before the runs), raw data and transcripts: **codingWithGPT/20261017_comparisonReviewSkills** (README.md, results/, runs/). Text style: ASD-STE100 Simplified Technical English, about 80% adherence.